

Data Center Opposition: Understanding Ontario Policy Implications | Salim Furth posted on the topic | LinkedIn

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Source Content

Helpful and insightful post from Andrew Miller on the seriousness of various reasons for opposition to data center construction. It's framed around Ontario policy, but I found that focus useful as a non-Ontarian, because the specific issues (electrical generation capacity, property taxation) are different elsewhere with different implications. I still think that the opposition to data centers is undertheorized. It's something that policy wonks need to understand better. <https://lnkd.in/edTaSAZQ> Data Center Opposition: Understanding Ontario Policy Implications More Relevant Posts - Data centers are becoming an increasingly important land-use issue across Volusia County as local governments consider how large facilities could affect electricity, water resources, utilities, development patterns, and surrounding communities. Volusia County is researching potential regulations and a possible temporary moratorium, while Ormond Beach has already approved the first reading of an 18-month moratorium and is working toward possible Comprehensive Plan and Land Development Code changes. A new Florida law also gives local governments express authority to regulate data centers and their impacts. For residents, property owners, buyers, and sellers throughout the Daytona Beach area, these discussions are worth watching because today's land-use decisions can shape tomorrow's growth and infrastructure. <https://lnkd.in/e8JuXiff> To view or add a comment, sign in - Belinda DennettTim Marshall This is excellent advice. I would add that one of the reasons land zoned industrial close to residential land is cheap is exactly because other potential developers know the cost of dealing with development objections. Back in the early 2000s the telco sector was having all sorts of trouble with building base stations and they had a planning exemption power which they were misusing. Slightly different issue because they could share sites so coordinating the way the mobile carriers did is not really possible. The 'best' solution in this space - recognising that the sector is competitive - would be a rapid process by which the State Governments - in conjunction with Councils and water and energy authorities - identified Data Centre development sites to which a shortened approval process could apply. That would include issues such as distance from residential areas, nature of emergency generation (gas would be cleaner and safer than diesel - not sure why it currently isn't used), potential density of data centres (e.g. an area might be designated as capable of holding only X number of centres, availability of water and energy infrastructure. The author of the original piece is right - current performance is only going to strengthen resistance and no amount of 'greater good' arguments to governments can overcome potential voter reaction. That is, you can't invoke the government to tell the citizens to just cop it. Data centre developers... save yourselves

some money on lobbyists. Stop developing sites next to residential communities. Yes, of course the land is zoned for industrial use. Yes, you are entitled to build there under current planning rules. Yes, in a technical sense you should be able to secure a planning permit because of the rules in place right now. But why are you provoking nearby residents who have invested their life savings into their homes? Why don't you plan your projects with proper buffer zones, or pick sites that don't have homes nearby? Don't you want a long term future for your industry? Do you want to antagonise communities and force politicians into knee-jerk responses? Do you want your industry to become hated? Because that is where you are headed. Every industry has bad apples. Every company will sometimes push the limits and get people offside. But right now would be a good time for the data centre development industry to wake up. If you're a developer and you keep getting this wrong then your customers (the global giants of cloud storage and AI) will abandon you because they don't want your controversy to become their controversy. Don't keep telling investors that your industry is "the future" of our economy when you act like you are only in it for a quick buck. <https://lnkd.in/gSypjAQj> To view or add a comment, sign in - Data centre developers... save yourselves some money on lobbyists. Stop developing sites next to residential communities. Yes, of course the land is zoned for industrial use. Yes, you are entitled to build there under current planning rules. Yes, in a technical sense you should be able to secure a planning permit because of the rules in place right now. But why are you provoking nearby residents who have invested their life savings into their homes? Why don't you plan your projects with proper buffer zones, or pick sites that don't have homes nearby? Don't you want a long term future for your industry? Do you want to antagonise communities and force politicians into knee-jerk responses? Do you want your industry to become hated? Because that is where you are headed. Every industry has bad apples. Every company will sometimes push the limits and get people offside. But right now would be a good time for the data centre development industry to wake up. If you're a developer and you keep getting this wrong then your customers (the global giants of cloud storage and AI) will abandon you because they don't want your controversy to become their controversy. Don't keep telling investors that your industry is "the future" of our economy when you act like you are only in it for a quick buck. <https://lnkd.in/gSypjAQj> To view or add a comment, sign in - Charlotte's pause on new data centers is nearly halfway over. An extension of the 150-day moratorium isn't off the table as city leaders weigh what regulations are legally possible under state law. <https://lnkd.in/dKYwY-xq>  Photo courtesy of Ashley Fahey/The Charlotte Ledger. #CharlotteNC #CLT #DataCenters #CharlotteNews #Growth #CharlotteLedger #NorthCarolina #CLTnews To view or add a comment, sign in - Faster approval process combined with clearer and stronger expectations for developing data centres in NSW. Good news for community and companies like CDC who have been building and operating data centres to high standards for many years. This will separate the serious from the speculative and address many of the frustrations community have been expressing. Implementation will be important to ensure these new stronger guidelines deliver the certainty, higher standards and investment that industry and community expect. <https://lnkd.in/gCS5xQz7> To view or add a comment, sign in - \$130 billion in U.S. data center projects were blocked or delayed by community opposition in Q1 2026 alone — a single quarter that matched the total for all of 2025, according to Data Center Watch. Project cancellations quadrupled from 6 in 2024 to 25 in 2025. Q1 2026 saw 20 more killed — a record quarterly pace. The moratorium map tells the story. Denver passed a unanimous city council moratorium on May 19, 2026. Seattle followed within weeks after 93,270 constituent emails. New York's statewide moratorium passed both legislative chambers on June 5 and awaits the governor's signature. Three hundred-plus state bills were filed across 30 states in six weeks. The industry is spending approaching \$1 trillion on infrastructure in 2026 against a permitting environment that voted unanimously against it in Denver last month. Our latest analysis documents the full scope of this structural shift — and the concrete evidence that developers who adopt proactive engagement and binding sustainability commitments before opposition forms have materially better permitting trajectories than

those who don't. The differentiated path exists. The question is whether the industry moves before 300-plus state bills create a regulatory patchwork that makes the decision for them. Full analysis: <https://lnkd.in/gmbayjHV> #DataCenters #EnergyPolicy #Infrastructure #PermittingReform #AllInfrastructure To view or add a comment, sign in - What's the biggest difference in Texas between a city and a county when it comes to data center development? A city needs a city council meeting. A county needs the Legislature. Texas cities already have zoning authority. If a city wants stronger development standards for data centers, the city council can act. Counties can't. They only have the authority the Legislature gives them. If they want land use tools for data centers, state law has to change. Moratoriums only delay projects. Cities that adopt clear development standards won't just protect residents. They'll attract better projects. Serious developers want certainty. Operators looking for loopholes don't. Clear rules don't stop development. They attract responsible development. <https://lnkd.in/gQ3yVzeG> To view or add a comment, sign in - La Crosse's Judiciary and Administration Committee advanced two significant proposals Wednesday night that would reshape city governance and pause data center development while officials assess potential impacts. To view or add a comment, sign in - NEW PERSPECTIVE: Data center opposition is becoming more technically consequential. (Observations from yesterday's news.) The emerging pattern is not simply that communities are objecting to data centers. They are concentrating on the specific systems that make large campuses possible. Virginia Mercury reported that residents raised concerns about generators, transmission, construction, water and noise around Tract's proposed 900 MW campus in Goochland County. The project has not been rejected, and a conditional-use application had not yet been filed. Even so, its operating infrastructure is already shaping the approval path. The Memphis Commercial Appeal documented a later-stage version of the same pattern around xAI-linked facilities: Clean Air Act litigation, a resident class action and an appeal of Mississippi's permit for 41 turbines. In Texas, organizing has similarly focused on environmental permits, grid demand, incentives and public testimony. Outcomes differ across jurisdictions, so this is not evidence of a uniform veto against development. It is reinforcing evidence that opposition is becoming component-specific. A project can face pressure through a turbine permit, transmission route, cooling choice or water system even when the data halls themselves remain viable. For developers, community engagement is therefore becoming part of technical execution—not a communications exercise added after the design is settled. Follow for Daily Insights. Hundreds of fresh articles contribute to our briefing every day - read the latest: https://lnkd.in/e_gtQkRY To view or add a comment, sign in - Montgomery County has unanimously voted to pause new data center developments for the next 18 months while it evaluates the long-term impacts on energy, water, and infrastructure. The decision highlights a broader challenge facing many local governments: how to balance the economic benefits of data centers with community and environmental considerations. Looking just across the Potomac, data centers have become a major economic driver in Virginia, supporting commercial real estate demand, attracting technology investment, and generating significant tax revenue. Up the road in Frederick County, the Quantum Loophole campus is projected to contribute more than \$65 million annually in real property taxes once fully operational. While Montgomery County currently has only a limited number of large-scale data center proposals, this moratorium underscores important policy questions and community concerns that remain unanswered. <https://lnkd.in/ebXYHzuX> To view or add a comment, sign in